

ART & CULTURE



INDIAN ARCHITECTURE

MODULE - 13

POST-MAURYAN ART-III

- AMARAVATHI SCHOOL
- PREVIOUS YEARS QUESTIONS

POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

AMARAVATI SCHOOL



Depiction of the Amaravathi stupa
from the site

- 1 Amravati Style of Art, evolved in Amaravati, (Andhra Pradesh), was patronized first by the Satavahanas and later by the Ikshvakus and also by other groups, flourished for nearly six centuries.
- 2 While the other two schools focused on single images, Amaravati School put more emphasis on the use of dynamic images or narrative art.

POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

AMARAVATI SCHOOL



3 Buddhist art and a large religious complex of Buddhism grew around Amravati which represent the revival of uniquely different regional art style.

4 The doctrine changes in Buddhism well as rise and fall of dynasties influenced the evolution of the Amravati School of Art.

POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

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- 5** The Amarāvātī stupa **begun about 200 BC** and underwent several renovations and additions.



- 6** One of the largest stupas built in Buddhist India, it was about 160 feet (50 m) in diameter and 90 to 100 feet (about 30 m) high.

- 7** But **it has been largely destroyed**, much of the stone having been used by local contractors during the 19th century to make lime mortar.

- 8** Many of the surviving narrative reliefs and decorative plaques are in the **Government Museum, Madras, and the British Museum.**

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- 9** The reliefs, carved on the **greenish white limestone** characteristic of the region, mostly depict events of the Buddha's life and his previous births (Jātaka stories).
- 10** The **crowded yet unified compositions** of the later period are filled with dynamic movement, a keen awareness of the **dramatic**, and a **delight in the sensuous world**.
- 11** There is an abundance of people and a richness of forms so overwhelming that the **frame is barely able to contain the sculpture**.

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- 12** The four centuries over which the style developed were also a period of change from aniconic to iconic representation of the Buddha, and at Amarāvātī both methods of depiction appear together—the iconic being represented by images of the seated and standing Buddha, and the aniconic by an empty throne symbolizing his presence.

Figure: An aniconic representation of Mara's assault on the Buddha, with an empty throne

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Figure: Another aniconic representation of the Buddha

- 13** Amaravati sculptures have a sense of movement and energy with **profound and quiet naturalism** in human, animal and floral forms.
- 14** Prominent places where this style developed are **Amravati, Goli, Nagarjunikonda, Ghantasala** etc.
- 15** Symbolic representation of Buddha's life, the Buddha almost always being represented by a symbol, though in two or three places he is personified.

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- 16** Like the Sanchi Stupa, the Amaravati Stupa also has pradakshina patha enclosed within a vedika on which many narrative stories from the life of Buddha and bodhisattva dominating such episodes relating to the Birth, the miracles, Enlightenment and the victory over Mara, about Tushita heaven etc.
- 17** Sculptural form in Amravati Art is characterised by intense emotions as the figures are slim, have a lot of movement, bodies are shown with three bents (i.e. tribhanga), and the sculptural anatomy is more complex than at Stupa of Sanchi.

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WHAT DOES THIS FIGURE SIGNIFY?

A drum slab carved in limestone with four events related to Buddha's birth:

1. *Top right- Mayadevi's dream*
2. *Top left- The interpretation of the dream attended by dikpalas*
3. *Bottom right- the birth of Buddha attended by dikpalas*
4. *Bottom left- the presentation of the Buddha to the chaityas of the Sakyas*

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18 Both religious and secular images were present in this style.

19 Subject matter of the various stone friezes range from mythological stories- typically from the Buddha's life, royal palaces to the life of common man.

Figure: A stone frieze representing the life of a common man

DIFFERENCES BETWEEN GANDHARA, MATHURA AND AMARAVATI SCHOOLS

BASIS	GANDHARA SCHOOL	MATHURA SCHOOL	AMARAVATI SCHOOL
External influence	Heavy influence of Greek or Hellenistic sculpture, so it is also known as Indo-Greek Art .	An indigenous school	An indigenous school
Ingredient used	Early Gandhara School used Bluish-Grey sandstone while the latter period saw the use of mud and stucco .	The sculptures of Mathura School were made using spotted red sandstone .	The sculptures of Amaravati School were made using white marbles

DIFFERENCES BETWEEN GANDHARA, MATHURA AND AMARAVATI SCHOOLS

BASIS	GANDHARA SCHOOL	MATHURA SCHOOL	AMARAVATI SCHOOL
Religious influence	Mainly Buddhist imagery , influenced by the Greco-Roman pantheon.	Influence of all three religions of the time i.e Hinduism, Jainism and Buddhism.	Mainly Buddhist inflence
Patronage	Patronized by Kushana rulers	Patronized by Kushana rulers	Patronized by Satavahana Rulers
Area of Development	Developed in the North West Frontier , in the modern day area of Kandahar.	Developed in and around Mathura, Sonkh and Kankalitila . Kankalitilia was famous for Jain Sculptures	Developed in Krishna-Godavari lower valley , in and around Amaravati and Nagarjunakonda.

DIFFERENCE BETWEEN GANDHARA, MATHURA AND AMARAVATI SCHOOLS

BASIS	GANDHARA SCHOOL	MATHURA SCHOOL	AMARAVATI SCHOOL
Features of Buddha Sculpture	The Buddha is shown in a spiritual state , with wavy hair,. He wears fewer ornaments and seated in the position of Yogi. The eyes are half-closed as in meditation . A protuberance is shown on the head signifying the omniscience of Buddha.	Buddha is shown in delighted mood with a smiling face. The body is muscular. The face and head are shaven. Buddha is seated in Padmasana with different mudras and his face reflects grace. A similar protuberance is shown on the head.	Since the sculptures are generally part of a narrative art , there is less emphasis on the individual features of Buddha. The sculptures generally depict life stories of Buddha and the Jataka Tales , i.e. previous lives of Buddha in both human and animal form.

PRELIMS 2013

In the context of cultural history of India, a pose in dance and dramatics called Tribhanga has been a favorite of Indian artists from ancient times till today. Which one of the following statements best describes this pose?

- a) One leg is bent and the body is slightly but oppositely curved at waist and neck.
- b) Facial expressions, hand gestures and make-up are combined to symbolize certain epic or historic characters.
- c) Movements of body, face and hands are used to express oneself or to tell a story.
- d) A little smile, slightly curved waist and certain hand gestures are emphasized to express the feeling of love or eroticism.

Answer: A

PRELIMS 2013

Some Buddhist rock-cut caves are called Chaityas, while the others are called Viharas. What is the difference between the two?

- a) Vihara is a place of worship, while Chaitya is the dwelling place of the monks.
- b) Chaitya is a place of worship, while Vihara is the dwelling place of the monks.
- c) Chaitya is the stupa at the far end of the cave, while Vihara is the hall axial to it.
- d) There is no material difference between the two.

Answer: B

PRELIMS 2016

Consider the following statements with reference to the religious history of India

1. The concept of Bodhisattva is central to Hinayana sect of Buddhism.
2. Bodhisattva is a compassionate one on his way to enlightenment.
3. Bodhisattva delays achieving his own salvation to help all sentient beings on their path to it.

Which of the above is / are correct?

- | | |
|---------------|-----------------|
| a) 1 only | b) 2 & 3 only |
| c) 1 & 2 only | d) All 1, 2 & 3 |

Answer: B

PRELIMS 2017

The painting of Bodhisattva Padampani is one of the most famous and oft-illustrated paintings at

- a) Ajanta
- b) Badami
- c) Bagh
- d) Ellora

Answer: A

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suggestions@learningspace.in

To Contact us:

info@learningspace.in

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G. V. Rao

K. Srikanth

D. Sunil Kumar

L. V. Krishna

Y. Deepthi

Amrita Naidu

M. Binukrishna

G. Ravi Babu

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